to BDPL. Post a preliminary discussion with I-T officers in Bhubaneswar on December 12, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) seemed set to step in to probe possible money-laundering.

Handed a television-worthy spectacle that left the country stunned, it was natural that the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) wasted no time in milking the situation. "In India, who needs 'Money Heist' fiction, when you have the Congress Party, whose heists are legendary for 70 years and counting!" PM Narendra Modi said on X on December 12. And Union home minister Amit Shah taunted Opposition parties and the INDIA bloc for remaining silent on the issue. With the 2024 general election just months away, it won't be surprising if the BJP tries to make hay of this, especially in Bihar, West Bengal, Jharkhand and Odisha, where it's in the Opposition. Already in Odisha, its state unit is pointing fingers at the Biju Janata Dal (BJD) government for allegedly giving a free hand to the Sahus. The BJD, in turn, has chosen to deflect these charges by pointing out how the saffron party's top leaders are blaming the Congress instead.

The Congress, meanwhile, has distanced itself and left it to Sahu to "explain" himself. "The Indian National Congress is in no way connected with the businesses of Dheeraj Sahu, MP," the party's communications chief, Jairam Ramesh, said on X. "Only he can explain, and should explain, how huge amounts of cash have been reportedly unearthed by income-tax authorities from his properties." But it won't be easy for the party to dodge inquiries so easily. Sahu has been involved with various parliamentary panels and continues to be a member of the power and renewable energy consultative committee, as well as the panel on coal, mines and steel. Son of freedom fighter Baldeo Sahu, he had started his political journey with the Congress's student wing NSUI in 1977. The party fielded his brother, Gopal, in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls (he lost); his elder brother, the late Shivprasad Sahu, was a two-term Congress MP from Ranchi. That's a legacy fully blackened. ■



BRAYING A CRISIS
A trader paints a donkey at the Vautha fair, Oct. 2022

GUJARAT

THE DONKEYS ARE VANISHING

By Jumana Shah

In a state known more for its lions, Gujarat may not automatically evoke the more humdrum image of the donkey, the four-legged beast trapped on the opposite side of human valuation. Least of all, concerns related to their falling numbers. But take the old dusty road down to Vautha village, bang in the centre of Gujarat, where Ahmedabad district brushes against the borders of Kheda, and what strikes you with a sudden pathos is the sense of a species-level crisis, of how close another familiar animal figure is to leaving behind an ecological void.

Vautha hosts an annual mela that's like a national trade fair for donkeys. But Mahendrasinh Mandora, former sarpanch of Vautha, expresses uncertainty about the event's future. Ever since the Vautha Lok Melo commenced six decades ago, it has traditionally attracted over 20,000 donkeys from Haryana, Rajasthan, Maharashtra and all over Gujarat. But the numbers have been declining sharply: this year, it notched up less than 4,000. Even that was a slight dip over last year. This matches the alarming decline in overall population, nationally and in Gujarat. According to the last livestock census, the state's donkey population plummeted by 71 per cent from 38,993 in 2012 to 11,291 in 2019. Nationally, the decline stands at 62 per cent, from 320,000 in 2012 to 120,000 in 2019.

The reasons are not hard to grasp. As a sturdy pack animal, the donkey has been the mainstay of logistics in rural India ever since the dawn of history. It's a role that's been usurped by mechanised transport, even if not fully yet. Within Gujarat,